frontiers to the west and north. China's exposure to Buddhism from India in the early centuries of the first millennium had a lot to do with how India was perceived in contrast to the nomadic tribes on its frontiers. But the Chinese traditional literati, including Confucian and Taoist scholars, were dismissive of Buddhism and the Buddhist monks who came from India. There were periods of persecution of Buddhists during the reign of several Chinese rulers. During these phases, Buddhism was rejected as a barbarian and alien influence, and India too was included in the category of barbarian nations. But this was the exception rather than the rule. Gradually, Buddhism took root among the ordinary people of China and, over the centuries, became Sinicized. China emerged as an alternative centre of the Buddhist faith, with its own doctrinal contributions, places of pilgrimage and spiritual masters.

Despite the patronage of the Han emperor Mingdi, Buddhism did not really take root in China during the Han period. The royal court and the literati may have been suspicious of this alien faith and its strange tenets. The Confucian orthodoxy had already taken root and may have felt threatened by the new system and the tenets and ritual practices of Buddhism. It was in the subsequent period of political turmoil and the rise of multiple kingdoms, both Han and non-Han, that Buddhism began to enjoy royal patronage and gain popular acceptance. This was the period of the Six Dynasties (220–589 CE) and the partial unification during the Sui dynasty (581–618 CE). Buddhist iconography entered the realm of Chinese art with models drawn from the Gandhara region.

In early references to India, the country is said to have five regions – east, west, north, south and the middle or central region. In some accounts, the central region or the Gangetic plain is called Zhonguo or 'Central Country' – a term that is usually used to denote China as the Middle Kingdom.

The pilgrim Fa Xian who visited India in the fifth century CE referred to the country south and east of the Indus as constituting the 'Madhya-desa' or Central Country. In such accounts, China was described as lying on the eastern periphery of India. It is not clear where this five-region division of India comes from, but it continued to be the frame defining India's structure